

Planning the raid

By the summer of 1859, Brown had switched his focus to Virginia. His target was the federal armory at Harpers Ferry, which would provide arms for some 18,000 slaves living in the surrounding counties. He already had a large quantity of weapons. The Massachusetts-Kansas Committee provided him with 200 Sharps rifles in 1857 and he paid a Connecticut blacksmith to craft 1,000 pikes with 10-in (25-cm) blades. He shipped 198 rifles and 950 of the pikes to the Maryland farm near Harpers Ferry, where his men were to gather. At a secret meeting in Chambersburg, Pennsylvania, Brown tried to persuade abolitionist Frederick Douglass to participate in the raid. He refused, warning Brown that the enterprise seemed doomed. Brown also tried to recruit Harriet Tubman, who had helped him plan raids, but she declined after falling ill.



Confiscated pike

This pike was confiscated at the time of John Brown's capture at Harpers Ferry. Brown commissioned 1,000 such weapons with a view to arming insurgent slaves.

Sentenced to death

Douglass's misgivings proved correct. The attackers failed to remove the arsenal's weapons and only five escaped capture and death. Brown's trial was swift. He had been wounded in the raid, but was declared fit to stand trial at Charles Town, Virginia, on October 27. Found guilty of treason against Virginia, he was sentenced to hang on December 2.

Americans generally condemned Brown's violence, but views on his goals and courage were divided. Abolitionist Lydia Maria Child wrote to Virginia Governor Henry Wise and offered to nurse Brown as he awaited execution. Republican newspapers noted Brown's extremism, but reminded readers that it resulted from the moral and political evils of slavery. Southern editors pointed out that no slaves had joined Brown's attack. On October 26, 1859, a North